



THE FULL STORY — EASY ENGLISH

CAPTAIN G. R. GOPINATH

From a village in Karnataka to the skies of India

The A-to-Z story of the man who started **India's first low-cost airline, Air Deccan** — army captain, farmer, helicopter pioneer, author, politician and the real-life hero behind two films.

Born 13 Nov 1951 Gorur, Hassan, Karnataka	Army 8 years 1971 war veteran	Founder Air Deccan India's 1st LCC, 2003	Rolex Laureate 1996 eco-farming	Author "Simply Fly" memoir, 2010	Films Soorai Pottru & Sarfira
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A 15-page picture story • Easy English • Timeline, quotes, lessons & photos inside

MEET THE MAN WHO MADE INDIA FLY

His full name is **Gorur Ramaswamy Iyengar Gopinath** — but everyone calls him **Captain Gopinath** or just “**Captain Gopi**”. He was born on **13 November 1951** in a small village called **Gorur**, in Hassan district, Karnataka, into a Tamil Iyengar family of modest means. His father was a school teacher. As a boy he rode bullock carts. As a man, he started an airline that took millions of ordinary Indians into the sky for the first time. His life has one simple message: **where you start never decides where you can reach**.

This PDF tells his full story in easy English, step by step — what he did in the army, on the farm, in business, in politics and in the sky — together with real photos, an A-to-Z summary, a timeline, his awards and the lessons young people can learn from him.

Full name	Gorur Ramaswamy Iyengar Gopinath
Nickname	Gopi / Captain Gopi
Born	13 November 1951, Gorur (Hassan), Karnataka
Family	Wife Bhargavi; daughters Pallavi and Krithika
Education	Sainik School Bijapur, NDA Pune, IMA Dehradun
Known as	Founder of Air Deccan, India’s first low-cost airline (2003)
Other roles	Army officer, farmer, helicopter-charter pioneer, author, politician
Famous quote	“He (Mallya) is from Venus, I am from Mars.”

“I have never seen a man who can't fly if he truly dreams. From a bullock cart, I went to owning an airline — if I can, anyone can.”

— the spirit of Captain Gopinath’s own memoir, “Simply Fly”

DID YOU KNOW? This story is true

Gopinath is a real, living person. His story is told in his autobiography “Simply Fly: A Deccan Odyssey” (2010) and in many newspapers and interviews. This PDF is a simple summary made from public information. Sources are listed on the last page.

The Village Boy of Gorur (1951-19

Gopinath grew up near the **Hemavati river** in Gorur, surrounded by paddy fields, coconut trees and small farms. His father, **Gorur Ramaswamy Iyengar**, was a respected school teacher who believed that ordinary schools made children too disciplined and dull. So he decided to teach young Gopi at home first. (Fun fact: a famous Kannada writer of the same name, Gorur Ramaswamy Iyengar, was Gopinath’s mother’s uncle.)

Because he studied at home, Gopinath joined a Kannada-medium school late — directly in **Class 5**. He spoke Kannada with friends and Tamil at home. Money was short, life was simple, but the boy was full of energy and curiosity. He watched bullock carts, trains and buses, and like every village child he dreamed of a bigger world. Nobody in

his family had ever flown in an aeroplane — flying was a rich man's dream. Little Gopi would one day change that for the whole country.

“If a boy from a bullock cart can build an airline, then no dream is too big for anyone.”

— the message of Gopinath's memoir “Simply Fly”

School, Exams in Kannada, and the Army (1962-1971)

When he was about eleven, Gopinath decided he wanted to join the army. In **1962** he sat the entrance test for **Sainik School, Bijapur** — a military school that prepared boys for the National Defence Academy (NDA). He **failed the first time**, mainly because the exam was in English and he was not fluent in it. Many boys would have given up. Instead, his headmaster wrote to the Defence Ministry, and Gopinath got special permission to write the exam **in Kannada**. He passed the second time.

At Sainik School he worked hard and cleared the NDA entrance. For three years he trained at the **National Defence Academy, Pune**, then moved to the **Indian Military Academy (IMA), Dehradun**. He was still a cadet when war broke out in **1971** (the India-Pakistan war that created Bangladesh). His training was cut short and he was sent to join his unit — he was just 20 years old.

DID YOU KNOW? He never forgot his Kannada roots

Gopinath wrote his army entrance exam in Kannada because English was weak. Later, as Air Deccan's chairman, he proudly advertised in Kannada, Tamil, Telugu and Hindi newspapers — not just English. The lesson: never be ashamed of where you come from; use it as your strength.

Captain in the Indian Army: 8 Years (1971-1979)

Gopinath was commissioned as an officer in the **Indian Army** and served in the **1971 war**, then on postings including Sikkim. He rose to the rank of **Captain**. Army life taught him discipline, courage, leadership and how to work with all kinds of people — lessons he used all his life.

But Gopinath was restless. Promotion in peacetime is slow, and he wanted to do more with his life. At the age of **28**, he took early retirement and returned to his village. His parting money was tiny — his army gratuity was only about **₹6,500**. His friends thought he was crazy. A captain with eight years of service, leaving the safe uniform to become... what? He himself did not know yet. But as he wrote later, he wanted to be the master of his own life.

DID YOU KNOW? The Army gift that never left him

Gopinath often says the army gave him two things no college can: **discipline** and the habit of turning impossible orders into possible actions. When bankers later laughed at his airline plan, he behaved like a soldier — he found another way.

The Farmer Who Won the Rolex A

Back home, Gopinath's land near the river was often flooded and hard to farm. Instead of giving up, he studied the problem like a scientist and started **sericulture — rearing silkworms to make silk** — in a completely natural, eco-friendly way, without poisonous chemicals. He planted mulberry trees, built a model farm and even helped other poor farmers learn his methods.

His work became world-famous. In **1996**, he won the **Rolex Awards for Enterprise** — a prestigious international prize given to people whose projects improve the world. Here was a village farmer who had never been to an agriculture college, receiving one of the world's most respected awards for enterprise. It proved to Gopinath that **a small person with a big idea can win on the world stage**.



Silkworms and mulberry leaves — Gopinath's eco-friendly sericulture farm won the Rolex Laureate Award in 1996 (illustration).

Many Small Businesses: Bikes, Ho 1980s-1990s)

Gopinath did not become rich overnight. He tried many honest businesses in and around Hassan: he ran a **Royal Enfield motorcycle dealership** called Malnad Mobikes, opened a **small hotel**, traded shares, and did agriculture consultancy. Some worked, some did not — but every business taught him how money moves, how customers think, and how to manage people.

He often laughs that he was India's most "well-rounded" businessman: soldier, farmer, bike dealer, hotelier, stock-market man. When he finally moved to **Bengaluru in 1992**, he carried all these experiences with him — and in Bangalore he met an old army friend who would change his life: **Captain K. J. Samuel**, a freelance pilot who dreamed of starting a helicopter company.

Helicopters First: Deccan Aviation

In 1995 the Indian government opened the skies — it relaxed the rules so private companies could run air services. Gopinath and Samuel joined hands and founded **Deccan Aviation**. In **1997** operations began with a tiny office on Infantry Road,

Bengaluru and just **one hired helicopter**.

It was a nerve-racking start. Permissions took years; money was always short. In his book, Gopinath remembers the first helicopter reaching Bengaluru **only minutes before the inauguration ceremony**, with the Chief Minister of Karnataka waiting to launch the company.

Soon Deccan Aviation helicopters were flying everywhere: politicians chartered them for elections, and the company carried out **rescue and relief missions in Sri Lanka, Nepal, Kabul and South India** (including tsunami relief in 2004). It grew into one of the largest private air-charter companies in India and Sri Lanka.



A Deccan Charters helicopter on display in Bengaluru — the company Captain Gopinath co-founded in 1997 (photo: Wikimedia Commons).

The Big Idea: A Flight That Changed India (1998-2003)

Once, flying inside the USA on **Southwest Airlines** (a famous low-cost airline), Gopinath sat next to a tattooed **carpenter** who was flying with his family on holiday. He looked around — the plane was full of ordinary workers, clerks, nurses. He asked himself: why do carpenters fly in America, but in India only rich people and businessmen fly?

At that time in India, flying was a luxury. One flight could cost more than a common man's monthly salary. Gopinath decided: **he would build an airline for the common man** — a no-frills, low-cost airline like Southwest and Ryanair, but made for India.

“There were more than a thousand flights a day from Phoenix airport. All the airports of India together had fewer. I saw the future — and it was for everyone, not just the rich.”

— Captain Gopinath’s famous realisation (as reported in the media)

Air Deccan Is Born: India’s First Low-Cost Airline (August 2003)

On **25 August 2003**, Air Deccan took off from **Bengaluru to Hubballi (Hubli)** — India’s first true low-cost airline. Gopinath raised the starting money (about **₹5 crore**) from his own savings and from friends and family. The first fleet was just two small **ATR-42** turboprop planes.

Air Deccan had no free meals, no luxury lounges, no VIP service — just safe, simple, cheap seats. The famous publicity trick was the **₹1 ticket**: for some seats the basic fare was just one rupee (taxes took the total to around ₹222). Ordinary Indians — farmers, shopkeepers, students, grandmothers — queued up for their first flight ever. Newspapers called it a revolution: **the common man’s airline**.



Air Deccan’s red-and-white ATR turboprop — the plane type with which Captain Gopinath started his dream airline in 2003 (photo: Wikimedia Commons).

DID YOU KNOW? ₹1 ticket — was it a trick?

Only a few seats per flight cost ₹1 — it was a marketing masterstroke, not a money-loser. But the message was real: **flying should belong to everyone**. Soon even the “regular” Air Deccan fare was often cheaper than an AC train ticket.

Flying High: Growth Like India Ha (2003-2007)

Air Deccan grew faster than anyone expected. It connected **small cities** — Hubli, Mangalore, Tirupati, Agartala, Jabalpur, Ranchi — that big airlines had ignored. In 2004 it added bigger **Airbus A320** jets; in December 2004 it ordered 30 A320s in a deal worth about **US\$1.8 billion**, and in 2005 it ordered 30 ATR-72 planes. By 2006 Air Deccan was India's **third-largest airline** with about a 19% share of the market; by 2007 it was the **second-largest**, flying to more than 60 cities with around 40 aircraft, carrying millions of first-time flyers.

In **May 2006**, Deccan Aviation went public — a successful IPO on the stock market. Gopinath became famous around the world. Magazines wrote about the “village boy who democratised the Indian sky”. He was even knighted by France with the **Chevalier de la Légion d’Honneur**.

25 Aug 2003	First flight: Bengaluru ↔ Hubli, with 2 ATR-42 planes
2004	Airbus A320 jets join; 30 more A320s ordered (US\$1.8 bn deal)
2005	30 ATR-72-500 turboprops ordered
2006	Deccan Aviation listed on the stock market; India's #3 airline
2006–07	Passenger traffic jumps 42%; becomes India's #2 airline
2007	Around 40 aircraft; 60+ cities connected; the “common man”; now flies

HOW AIR DECCAN KEPT TICKETS SO CHEAP (THE PLAYBOOK)

People often ask: how could any airline sell a seat for ₹1 and still survive? Air Deccan worked like a careful shopkeeper. Every rupee was counted, and every old habit of “luxury airlines” was removed:

No free meals	Passengers who wanted food could buy it on board. No free lunch, no free gifts.
No business class	One class for everyone — the plane carried more seats and no empty luxury.
One simple fleet	ATRs for short routes, A320s for big routes — same planes = cheaper training and repairs.
Fast turns	Planes landed, refuelled and took off quickly — more flying hours per plane per day.
Online tickets	Many tickets were sold on the Internet, which saved agent commissions — a new habit in 2003 India.
Smart pricing	Seats were released in batches: the first few cost ₹1 or ₹500, and the price rose as seats filled. Early bookers got the cheapest seats.
Small cities	Instead of fighting big airlines at big airports, Air Deccan flew to small cities where people were desperate to fly.

This playbook looks normal today — every budget airline in the world does it. But in 2003 India, it was revolutionary. That is why Air Deccan's fares were often 30% lower than full-service airlines' tickets, and why millions of first-time flyers suddenly found they could afford the sky.

The Kingfisher Merger — Sweet a

Flying was cheap, but diesel, airports and competition were costly. Big full-service airlines fought back, and new low-cost rivals (SpiceJet, GoAir, IndiGo) entered the market. Air Deccan grew very fast but also lost money — expansion was expensive. In **2007**, liquor baron **Vijay Mallya**, owner of Kingfisher Airlines, bought a strategic 26% stake, and in 2008 the airlines merged into **Simplify Deccan**. The Air Deccan brand finally disappeared into **Kingfisher Red** in August 2008.

Gopinath called the merger a marriage of opposite planets. When reporters first asked about Mallya, he famously joked that they were from different worlds.

“He is from Venus, I am from Mars.”

— Captain Gopinath on Vijay Mallya, when merger rumours began (2007)

The merger made money for investors, but it broke Gopinath’s heart — he had built the airline for the common man, and now the name was gone. By **2009** he had sold most of his shares. Many people thought his story was over. They were wrong — Captain Gopi always started again.

Start Again, Fail, Start Again: Car (2009-2020)

With money from the Kingfisher deal, Gopinath launched **Deccan 360**, a cargo airline, in **2009**. It hit a cash crunch and stopped in 2011; the Karnataka High Court finally ordered it wound up in 2013. He also bought back **Deccan Charters** fully from Mallya in 2011, and in 2012 started **Deccan Shuttles** in Gujarat — daily flights connecting Ahmedabad, Surat, Jamnagar, Bhavnagar and Kandla in small nine-seater planes. That service too ended in 2013.

In **April 2017**, under the government’s **UDAN scheme** (which supports flights to small cities), Deccan Charters won 34 regional routes and brought back the **Air Deccan** brand in **December 2017** with 19-seater Beechcraft planes, starting with Mumbai-Nashik. Money problems again limited the flights, and scheduled operations stopped in **April 2020** during the COVID lockdown.

The pattern is honest: Gopinath is a brilliant **starter**. He opens doors that others said were locked — and later, bigger players take over the road he built. He accepts this with a smile and moves to the next idea. That is also a lesson.

THE SKY HE LEFT BEHIND: INDIA BEFORE & AFTER AIR DECCAN

When Air Deccan began in 2003, only about **1.3 crore (13 million) people** flew inside India in a whole year. Flying was for businessmen, ministers and the very rich. Most Indians had never even seen an airport, and a plane ticket could cost more than a worker’s monthly salary.

Twenty years later, Indian airlines carry **more than ten times that number every year** — in recent years about 15 crore (150 million) domestic passengers a year, as per government figures. India is now one of the fastest-growing aviation markets in the world. Small cities have airports and flights — many connected under the government's **UDAN scheme**, which tries to do for small-town India exactly what Gopinath proved in 2003: **if fares are low and flights are reliable, ordinary Indians will fly.**

It is fair to say that every Indian low-cost airline that came later — SpiceJet (2005), IndiGo (2006), GoAir, Akasa Air (2022) — walks on the runway Captain Gopinath first built. When he started, people laughed: “Indians will never fly like Americans.” Today, crores of them do — and the man who opened that door was a village boy with a ₹1 ticket idea.

DID YOU KNOW? What happened to the Air Deccan brand?

Kingfisher Red (2008) closed when Kingfisher Airlines itself collapsed in 2012. Gopinath brought the Air Deccan name back for UDAN regional flights in 2017. Today, Deccan Charters still runs charter and helicopter services from Bengaluru — the small company that started it all keeps flying.

Politics: Fighting Two Elections (2

In **2009**, Gopinath stood as an **independent candidate** from the Bangalore South constituency in the Lok Sabha (national) elections. He lost. In **2014**, he joined the **Aam Aadmi Party (AAP)** and contested again from Bangalore South on its ticket. He lost again. Later he left the party, criticising what he called a lack of internal democracy.

Why would a successful businessman enter politics? He said the same reason as always: he wanted to serve common people and fight corruption. He did not win a seat, but he won respect for trying — he spent his own money, campaigned honestly, and never made a single false promise.

DID YOU KNOW? Losing was also a lesson

Gopinath lost every election he fought. He says it taught him humility: in business your customers vote with money, in politics people vote with their hearts. He accepted both results and moved on with grace.

THE MAN BEHIND THE CAPTAIN: F

Gopinath's wife **Bhargavi** married him when he was a restless ex-soldier with more dreams than money. Through the farm years, the small shops, the helicopter struggle and the airline madness, she kept the home strong. Their two daughters, **Pallavi and Krithika**, grew up with aviation talk at the dining table — and both later worked with Air Deccan. Gopinath openly says his family's trust was his biggest bank balance when no bank would lend him money.

Even today, in his seventies, the Captain keeps a simple style — no show-off, no gold chains, no fancy bungalow stories. He spends his time writing, talking to students and start-up founders, and pushing one message: **dream big, work honestly, and never be ashamed of a small beginning.**

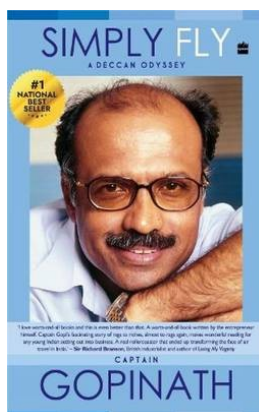
“Success is not a big car or a big office. Success is looking back and knowing you helped ordinary people do something they never thought possible.”

— the idea Captain Gopinath repeats in interviews (paraphrase of his own words)

Author & Movie Hero: His Story T (2010-2024)

In **2010** Gopinath published his famous autobiography **“Simply Fly: A Deccan Odyssey”** (translated into Kannada as “Baanayaana” and Hindi as “Udaan: Air Deccan ka Safar”). It became a bestseller and was loved by students and young entrepreneurs.

In **2020**, the Tamil film **“Soorarai Pottru”**, starring Suriya, was partly inspired by his life and won the National Film Award for best feature film. In **2024** it was remade in Hindi as **“Sarfire”**, starring Akshay Kumar. Suddenly a new generation discovered the village captain who made India fly.



Left: “Simply Fly” book cover. Middle: “Sarfire” (2024, Hindi). Right: “Soorarai Pottru” (2020, Tamil) — the films inspired by his story (promotional images; copyright with the publishers/studios).

Awards & Honours: From Rolex to

Over 50 years, Gopinath has collected honours from farming, business and society. The most important ones are listed below — but as he says, his biggest award is seeing ordinary people fly.

1996	Rolex Awards for Enterprise (Switzerland) — for eco-friendly silk farming
2005	Rajyotsava Award — the highest state honour of Karnataka
2006/07	Chevalier de la Légion dÙHonneur — FranceÙs highest civilian honour
—	Personality of the Decade Award (K.G. Foundation)
—	Sir M. Visvesvaraya Memorial Award (FKCCI, Karnataka)

2023	Honorary doctorate (D.Litt.) from ASBM University, Bhubaneswar, conferred by the President of India
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DID YOU KNOW? Inspiring two films is also an “award”

Rarely does a businessman’s life become a movie twice — in Tamil (Soorarai Pottru, 2020, which won the National Film Award) and in Hindi (Sarfira, 2024). Gopinath says he is touched that his struggle gives courage to young people.

LIFE AT A GLANCE: THE FULL TIMELINE

Here is Captain Gopinath’s whole journey on one page:

1951	Born on 13 November in Gorur village, Hassan district, Karnataka.
1962	Joins Sainik School, Bijapur — after passing the entrance exam in Kannada.
Late 1960s	Trains at the National Defence Academy (Pune) and the Indian Military Academy (Dehradun).
1971	Commissioned as an Army officer during the India–Pakistan (Bangladesh Liberation) War; first posting at age 20.
1970s	Serves for about 8 years; rises to the rank of Captain.
Late 1970s	Takes early retirement at 28 with a gratuity of about ₹6,500.
1980s	Returns to Gorur; builds an eco-friendly sericulture (silk) farm on difficult land near the river.
1992	Moves to Bengaluru; meets his old army friend, Captain K. J. Samuel, a pilot.
1995	Government opens private aviation; the two friends start planning a helicopter company.
1997	Deccan Aviation begins flying with one hired helicopter from a small Bengaluru office.
2000s	Deccan helicopters do rescue missions in Sri Lanka, Nepal, Kabul and South India.
2003	25 August: Air Deccan, India’s first low-cost airline, starts Bengaluru–Hubballi.
2004	Airbus A320 jets arrive; helicopters help in tsunami relief in Sri Lanka.
2005	Wins Rajyotsava Award (Karnataka); orders 30 ATR-72 turboprops.
2006	Deccan Aviation’s IPO; France honours him (Légion d’Honneur); airline is India’s #3.
2007	Air Deccan becomes India’s #2 airline; Vijay Mallya buys a 26% stake (May).
2008	Air Deccan merges into Kingfisher; the brand becomes Kingfisher Red by August.
2009	Starts Deccan 360 cargo airline; sells most of his Kingfisher-era shares; contests his first election (loses).
2011	Deccan 360 stops flying; Gopinath buys Mallya’s shares and owns Deccan Charters fully.
2012	Deccan Shuttles: daily small-plane flights inside Gujarat (ends 2013).
2013	Karnataka High Court orders the winding up of Deccan 360.
2014	Contests Lok Sabha election on the AAP ticket from Bangalore South (loses); later leaves AAP.
2017	Wins 34 UDAN routes; Air Deccan brand relaunches in December (Mumbai–Nashik).
2020	Scheduled Air Deccan (UDAN) flights pause during the COVID-19 lockdown.
2023	Receives an honorary doctorate (D.Litt.) from ASBM University, Bhubaneswar, from President Kovind.
2024	“Sarfira” (Hindi remake of Soorarai Pottru) releases; his story reaches a new generation.
Today	Still active in his seventies — writing, speaking and inspiring young India.

A TO Z: 26 WORDS THAT TELL HIS WHOLE STORY

From A to Z, here is everything Captain Gopinath did, in 26 easy words:

A Army Officer 8 years of service; fought in the 1971 war.	B Books Author of the bestseller “Simply Fly”.
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C Captain His army rank — and his famous title for life.	D Deccan His family of brands: Deccan Aviation, Charters, 360 & Air Deccan.
E Exam in Kannada Wrote the military entrance exam in Kannada and passed.	F Farmer Built an eco-friendly silk farm from useless, flooded land.
G Gorur His village birthplace on the Hemavati river.	H Helicopters Pioneered private helicopter charters in India (1997).
I India's 1st LCC Started the country's first low-cost airline (2003).	J Journey From bullock cart to airline chairman — his own words.
K Kingfisher Merged with Mallya's airline in 2007-08.	L Low fares The ₹1 ticket that made headlines worldwide.
M Malnad Mobikes His Royal Enfield bike dealership in Hassan.	N NDA Trained at the National Defence Academy, Pune.
O Optimism "Good things will happen" — his life motto.	P Politician Contested Lok Sabha elections twice (2009, 2014).
Q Questioning He always asked "why not?" when told something was impossible.	R Rolex Laureate Won the Rolex Award for Enterprise in 1996.
S Southwest flight The US flight beside a carpenter that sparked the idea.	T Tickets for all Made clerks, farmers and students able to fly.
U UDAN Brought the Air Deccan brand back under UDAN in 2017.	V Vijay Mallya The Kingfisher owner who bought and merged Air Deccan.
W War Served in the 1971 India-Pakistan war as a young officer.	X eXtraordinary restart Lost Air Deccan, yet started cargo, shuttles and more.
Y Yes attitude Said yes to every challenge life gave him.	Z Zest Still full of energy at 74 — writing, speaking and inspiring.

The alphabet ends at Z — but his story of service and courage never ends. That is the real A-to-Z of Captain Gopinath.

SIMPLE WORD MEANINGS (GLOSSARY)

Some words from this story, in easy English:

Airline A company that carries passengers or goods by aeroplane.	Low-cost carrier (LCC) A budget airline: low fares, no free meals, no luxury.
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Full-service airline A traditional airline with free meals, free luggage and premium class.	Charter Hiring a whole plane or helicopter for your own journey.
Sericulture Farming silkworms to make silk thread.	Turboprop An aeroplane whose engine turns a propeller; best for short routes.
ATR 42 / ATR 72 Small turboprop planes (built in France & Italy) with which Air Deccan started.	Airbus A320 A bigger jet used by Air Deccan on busy routes from 2004.
IPO Initial Public Offering — when a company first sells its shares to the public.	Gratuity Lump-sum money an employer gives a worker when they retire or leave.
UDAN A government scheme (“Ude Desh ka Aam Naagrik”) to connect small cities by air.	Market share The share of all passengers that one airline carries.

8 LESSONS FROM CAPTAIN GOPINATH

- **Where you start does not matter.** Village, small school, no money — he reached the world stage anyway.
- **Language is never a wall.** Weak English did not stop him; he took his exam in Kannada and later led a national company.
- **Learn by doing.** Soldier, farmer, bike seller, hotelier, share trader — every job added a skill.
- **Serve common people.** His airline was not about luxury; it was about giving the common man wings.
- **Do things honestly and cleanly.** His farming was chemical-free; his politics was promise-free; his flying was safe.
- **Restart after every loss.** He lost Air Deccan, Deccan 360 and two elections — and started something new each time.
- **Keep childlike optimism.** “You must have the spirit of optimism that good things will happen,” he tells youngsters.
- **Share your story.** His book and films now inspire millions — your struggle may be someone else’s fuel.

TEST YOURSELF: 10 QUESTIONS FROM THE STORY

Read the story, then try these questions. (Answers are at the bottom of the page — no cheating!)

- Q1.** In which village, district and state was Gopinath born, and on which date?
- Q2.** What was his father’s job?
- Q3.** In which language did he write the Sainik School entrance exam the second time?
- Q4.** How many years did he serve in the Army, and what was his final rank?

- Q5.** Which famous international award did he win in 1996, and for what?
- Q6.** What was the name and starting year of his helicopter company?
- Q7.** On which date did Air Deccan start, and which two cities were on the first route?
- Q8.** What was Air Deccan's famous lowest base fare?
- Q9.** Which airline merged with Air Deccan in 2007-08, and who owned it?
- Q10.** Name the Tamil film (2020) and the Hindi film (2024) inspired by his life.

Answers: 1. Gorur, Hassan, Karnataka — 13 November 1951 | 2. School teacher | 3. Kannada | 4. 8 years, Captain | 5. Rolex Awards for Enterprise, eco-friendly silk farming | 6. Deccan Aviation, 1997 | 7. 25 August 2003, Bengaluru-Hubballi | 8. ₹1 (base fare; with taxes about ₹222) | 9. Kingfisher Airlines, Vijay Mallya | 10. Soorarai Pottru and Sarfira.

WHAT OTHERS SAY ABOUT HIM

Newspapers, readers and filmmakers have described Captain Gopinath in many ways. Here are a few of their words:

"The airline entrepreneur who sought to democratize Indian skies."

— headline, Mint / Livemint (2026)

"From fighting for the country to making it fly — meet the man who made low-cost flights a reality in India."

— headline, YourStory (2017)

"You must have the spirit of optimism that good things will happen."

— Captain Gopinath's own advice, in a Forbes India interview (2024)

"He is a living example that a village boy can do anything: soldier, farmer, bike dealer, hotel owner, and finally the man who put the common man on a plane."

— readers of his memoir "Simply Fly"

SOURCES & PHOTO CREDITS

This PDF is a simple, easy-English summary prepared from publicly available information (checked September 2026). Main sources:

- [1] Wikipedia: "G. R. Gopinath", "Simplifly Deccan" and "Deccan Charters" articles.
- [2] "Simply Fly: A Deccan Odyssey" by Captain G. R. Gopinath (HarperCollins, 2010).
- [3] Mint / Livemint: "Capt. GR Gopinath: Airline entrepreneur who sought to democratize Indian skies" (2026).
- [4] Forbes India leadership interview with Captain Gopinath (photo credit: Amit Verma / Forbes India).
- [5] StarsUnfolded & TheCityCeleb: G. R. Gopinath biography quick facts.
- [6] YourStory: "From fighting for the country to making it fly" (2017).
- [7] BollywoodShaadis / Rozana Spokesman articles on the Sarfira real-life story (2024).
- [8] Padma/other award databases — note: no Padma award is listed in official records for him; award claims on some blogs are unverified.

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